

PrimeFocus

April 2026



WHEN

April 18, 2026

Doors open at 7:00pm

Meeting starts at 7:30pm

Lecture starts at 8:00pm

WHERE

Unitarian Church

1893 North Vasco Road

Livermore, CA 945571

and via Zoom

TVS QR CODE



INSIDE THIS ISSUE

This Month's Speaker	2
News and Notes	3
Calender of Events	3
TVS Astrophotography	4
What's Up	5
Navigating the Night Sky - April 2026	6
Potential Ranch Sale	7
Membership / Renewal Application	8

THIS MONTH'S SPEAKER

Asterisms - Connecting the Dots **Ron Kane**

Asterisms are star patterns that have a meaning or a shape and are commonly used in story-telling. One of the earliest is the Ursa Major - The Big Dipper - that stands out in the northern sky. Looks like a big saucepan outline but some cultures imagined a bear shape surrounding it. Takes imagination for that doesn't it! Some asterisms have been formalized into the 88 constellations we recognize. Other asterisms have been found and described and are now popular patterns to search for and learn about the stars. Tonight's talk is a bit of the origin of asterisms and what people do with them today. You too might someday find a star pattern you like and work at getting it recognized as an asterism. Do it quick though, asterisms, like the animals and faces you see in clouds, are going to change!



The Summer Triangle asterism hangs in the upper left corner of this image of the Milky Way.
NASA/Preston Dyches

Ron Kane is our presenter. He first attended TVS meetings in about 1984 and then other aspects of life took over. He's been a regular member for the past 10 or 15 years and you've seen him around a lot

NEWS AND NOTES

Meeting Dates

Club Meeting	Board Meeting	PrimeFocus Deadline
April 17	April 20	April 4
May 15	May 18	May 9
June 19	June 22	June 6

Money Matters

As of the last Treasurer’s Report on 3/23/26, our club’s account balance is \$54,807.84, this includes \$14,205.46 in the H2O Rebuild fund.

TVS Welcomes New Members

TVS welcomes new members Fernando Martinez, Biju Abraham, Mark Bowers, and Sudhish Verma. Please say hello and chat with them during our meetings.

2026 TVS Club Star Party Schedule

Save the dates for the 2025 Club Star Parties. Del Valle star parties are also public outreach events. They are jointly hosted with the EBRPD and held at the Arroyo Staging Area (Coords: 37.6196638, -121.7528899). The public is invited for the first 1.5-2 hours, while club members can stay the remainder of the night.

No events currently scheduled for Del Valle.

Tesla Vintners star parties are open to only club members and their guests. These star parties end at midnight, but participants can leave earlier, should they wish.

June 6: Tesla Vintner’s Star Party, 5143 Tesla Rd., Livermore. Set-up at 8:00pm, Observing 8:30-11:30pm.

August 8: Tesla Vintner’s Star Party, 5143 Tesla Rd., Livermore. Set-up at 7:30pm, Observing 8:00-Midnight.

October 10: Tesla Vintner’s Star Party, 5143 Tesla Rd., Livermore. Set-up at 6:30pm, Observing 7:00pm-11-30pm.

H2O Open House star parties are open to only club members and their guests. The open house ends at midnight, and all participants are encouraged to stay the duration. The drive to H2O takes about 1 hour, and the caravan leaves promptly from the corner of Mines and Tesla Rds. No gas stations are available on the route, so be prepared. Admission is \$3/car-bring exact change. H2O is a primitive site with two porta-potties. Bring water, food, and warm clothing, as needed. Red flashlights are to be used so observers can preserve their night vision.

May 9: H2O Open House, 5:00pm caravan to H2O PROMPTLY leaves the corner of Mines and Tesla Rds., Livermore. Observing until 11:30pm. Meeting times are tentative.

September 5: H2O Open House, 5:00pm caravan to H2O PROMPTLY leaves the corner of Mines and Tesla Rds., Livermore. Observing until 11:30pm. Meeting times are tentative.

April 18: 8th Annual Tri-Valley Innovation Fair (Solar Observing), Alameda County Fairgrounds - Court of Four Seasons. Set up 9:00 am, Observing from 10:00am - 5:00pm

May 23: Public Star Party at Sunol Regional Wilderness, 1895 Geary Road, Sunol. Set up 7:30. Observing starts 8:00 pm, ends about 9:30 or 10 pm. Map to parking lot: <https://maps.app.goo.gl/sGxWWiah37SY7rhN8>

CALENDAR OF EVENTS



April 17, 18, 24,25, May 1, 2, 8,9, 15, 16, 7:30-10:30pm

What	Free Telescope Viewing
Who	Chabot Staff
Where	Chabot Space and Science Center, 10000 Skyline Blvd. Oakland, CA 94619
Cost	Free

Join Chabot astronomers on the Observatory Deck for a free telescope viewing! Weather permitting, this is a chance to explore stars, planets and more through Chabot’s historic telescopes. Chabot’s three large historic telescopes offer a unique way to experience the awe and wonder of the Universe. Three observatory domes house the Center’s 8-inch (Leah, 1883) and 20-inch (Rachel, 1916) refracting telescopes, along with a 36-inch reflecting telescope (Nellie, 2003).

Are the skies clear for viewing tonight? Viewing can be impacted by rain, clouds, humidity and other weather conditions. Conditions can be unique to Chabot because of its unique location in Joaquin Miller Park. Before your visit, check out the Weather Station to see the current conditions at Chabot.

For more information, see <https://chabotspace.org/events/events-listing/> <https://eastbayastro.org/chabot-telescope-status/>



Copyright - SurinAsh

WHATS UP

Adapted from Sky and Telescope

All times are Pacific Standard Time

April 2026

17	Fri	New Moon
18	Sat	At sunset look for the thin sliver of the Moon and Venus as they descend toward the horizon
19	Sun	Just after sunset look for the Pleiades with the Moon just $4\frac{1}{2}^{\circ}$ above and Venus just $6\frac{1}{2}^{\circ}$ below
22	Mon	Lyrid meteor shower is expected to peak in the morning. Then at dusk, looking west, the Moon forms a tableau with Jupiter 3° lower left and Pollux $5\frac{1}{2}^{\circ}$ above
23	Tue	New Moon
24	Wed	Moon is at first quarter
25	Thu	Moon eclipses Leo's brightest star, Regulus at approximately 11:25 pm
29	Mon	Spica is a bit more than $2\frac{1}{2}^{\circ}$ left of the Moon

May 2026

1	Fri	Full Moon
3	Sun	Looking southeast, see the Moon trailing Antares by just $1\frac{1}{2}^{\circ}$
9	Sat	Moon is at last quarter
14	Thu	At dawn, see Mars trailing the Moon by just 7°
16	Sat	New Moon

OFFICERS AND VOLUNTEER POSITIONS

Officers	Volunteer Positions	Newsletter	Potluck Coordinator
President Eric Dueltgen president@trivalleystargazers.org	Astronomical League Rep. Don Dossa alrep@trivalleystargazers.org	Scott Schneider (Editor) newsletter@trivalleystargazers.org	OPEN potluck@trivalleystargazers.org
Vice-President Aris Pope vice_president@trivalleystargazers.org	Club Star Party Coordinator Johnathan Bailey coordinator@trivalleystargazers.org	Webmaster Swaroop Shere webmaster@trivalleystargazers.org	Program Coordinator Ron Kane programs@trivalleystargazers.org
Treasurer Ernest Epley treasurer@trivalleystargazers.org	Del Valle Coordinator David Wright delvalle@trivalleystargazers.org	Night Sky Network Rep. Ross Gaunt nnsn@trivalleystargazers.org	Publicity and Fundraising OPEN publicity@trivalleystargazers.org
Secretary Dave Lackey secretary@trivalleystargazers.org	Historian OPEN historian@trivalleystargazers.org	H2O Observatory Director / Rebuild Chairman Chuck Grant H2O@trivalleystargazers.org	Refreshment Coordinator OPEN
Past President Ron Kane past_president@trivalleystargazers.org	Librarian Ron Kane librarian@trivalleystargazers.org	Observing Program Coordinator Ron Kane awards@trivalleystargazers.org	Web and Email www.trivalleystargazers.org info@trivalleystargazers.org
	Loaner Scope Manager Ron Kane telescopes@trivalleystargazers.org	Outreach Coordinator Tom Dossa outreach@trivalleystargazers.org	TVS E-Group To Join the TVS E-Group just send an email to TVS at info@trivalleystargazers.org asking to join the group. Make sure you specify the email address you want to use to read and post to the group.

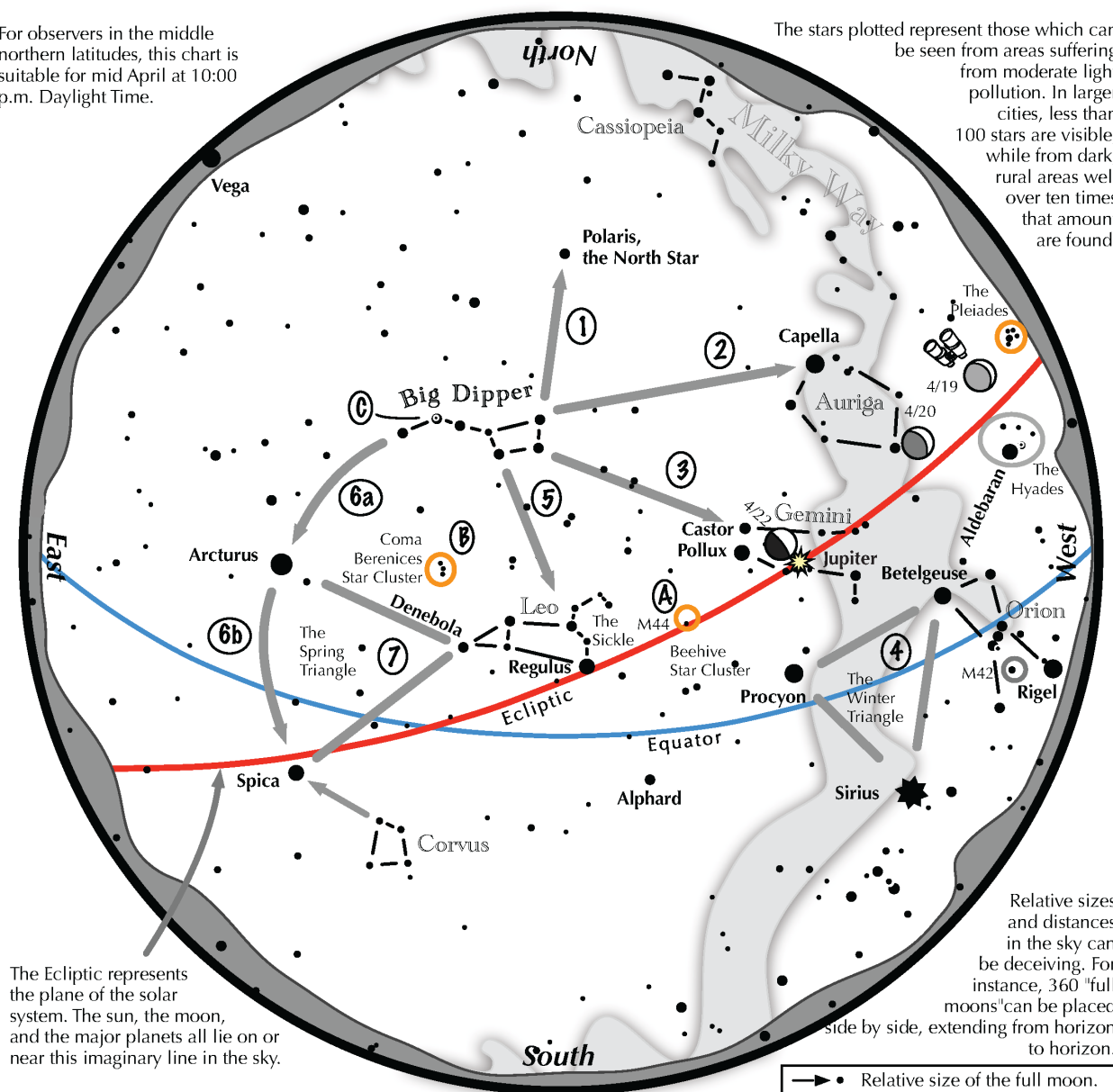
NAVIGATING THE NIGHT SKY FOR APRIL

Navigating the mid-April Night Sky

2026

For observers in the middle northern latitudes, this chart is suitable for mid April at 10:00 p.m. Daylight Time.

The stars plotted represent those which can be seen from areas suffering from moderate light pollution. In larger cities, less than 100 stars are visible, while from dark, rural areas well over ten times that amount are found.



The Ecliptic represents the plane of the solar system. The sun, the moon, and the major planets all lie on or near this imaginary line in the sky.

Relative sizes and distances in the sky can be deceiving. For instance, 360 "full moons" can be placed side by side, extending from horizon to horizon.

→ • Relative size of the full moon.

Navigating the April night sky: Simply start with what you know or with what you can easily find.

- 1 Extend an imaginary line north from the two stars at the tip of the Big Dipper's bowl. It passes Polaris, the North Star.
- 2 Draw another imaginary line west across the top two stars of the Dipper's bowl. It strikes Capella low in the northwest.
- 3 Through the two diagonal stars of the Dipper's bowl, draw a line pointing to the twin stars of Castor and Pollux in Gemini.
- 4 Look in the west-southwest for the bright Winter Triangle stars of Sirius, Procyon, and Betelgeuse.
- 5 Directly below the Dipper's bowl reclines the constellation Leo with its primary star, Regulus.
- 6 Follow the arc of the Dipper's handle. It first intersects Arcturus, then continues to Spica.
- 7 Arcturus, Spica, and Denebola form the Spring Triangle, a large equilateral triangle.

Binocular Highlights

- A: M44, a star cluster barely visible to the naked eye, lies to the southeast of Pollux.
 B: Look nearly overhead for the loose star cluster of Coma Berenices.
 C: In the Big Dipper's handle shines Mizar next to a dimmer star, Alcor.



Astronomical League
www.astroleague.org

Duplication allowed and encouraged for all free distribution.

POTENTIAL RANCH SALE PUTS H2O SITE INTO JEOPARDY

Hidden Hill Observatory (H2O) has operated at its present location since the early 80s. We have a very good relationship with the property owners, which has been a major factor in making TVS an attractive club to join. We have sunk a lot of money into the observatory with more planned as we rebuild from the devastating fire. However, the owners are facing financial difficulties and if they are not resolved, they will have to sell the ranch approximately by December this year.

If the ranch is sold, we may or may not be able to negotiate a deal with the new owners to continue to operate the observatory and dark site. If we can't strike a deal, we would lose the site and many tens of thousands of dollars we invested in infrastructure. We would be able to save the telescopes and mounts but probably not the domes. The club clearly does not have the resources to buy the ranch (or a significant stake in the ranch).

One desirable solution would be that a member of the club (or someone friendly with the club) could buy the ranch and allow the club to continue operating as we do now. Another possibility is that a coalition of members and others could buy the ranch. The current owners would probably be happy to stay on as live-in ranch managers. I don't have any exact numbers, but the ranch, I think, is about 75-100 acres, would probably go for somewhere around \$1.5 million (or about the same as a nice-ish four bedroom house in Livermore).

On the other hand, if the owners can increase their income it may be possible to avoid selling the ranch. The financial obligation that is causing the current problem is not one that will last forever. One possibility is that there are two residences at the ranch which could be rented out. The club probably does not have enough resources to do this, but it would be nice to have a warm building with electricity and plumbing available for visiting members. A member (or coalition of members) could rent one or both buildings and live there (or just rent them and not live there). But even if we could do this I don't know if this would be sufficient. The details would have to be worked out with the owners. A few thousand dollars a month would probably be sufficient, for some definition of "a few", but I don't have any exact numbers.

Another possibility is that a member or coalition of members could buy a stake in the ranch which generated enough capital or income to avoid selling the entire ranch.

Or, of course, direct gifts to the ranch would also work.

If anyone is interested in any of these options (no commitment) please contact me so we can begin exploring possibilities at observatory@trivalleystargazers.org. This would be a tremendous help to the future of the club.



Tri-Valley Stargazers
P.O. Box 2476
Livermore, CA 94551
www.trivalleystargazers.org

Tri-Valley Stargazers Membership Application

Contact information:

Name: _____ Phone: _____

Street Address: _____

City, State, Zip: _____

Email Address: _____

Status (select one): _____ New member _____ Renewing or returning member

Membership category (select one): Membership term is for one calendar year, January through December.

_____ Student member (\$10). Must be a full-time high-school or college student.

_____ Regular member (\$30).

Hidden Hill Observatory Access (optional): Must be 18 or older.

_____ One-time key deposit (\$20). This is a refundable deposit for a key to H2O. New key holders must first hear an orientation lecture and sign a usage agreement form before using the observing site.

_____ Annual access fee (\$10). You must also be a key holder to access the site.

Donation (optional):

_____ Tax-deductible contribution to Tri-Valley Stargazers

Total enclosed: \$ _____

Member agrees to hold Tri-Valley Stargazers, and any cooperating organizations or landowners, harmless from all claims of liability for any injury or loss sustained at a TVS function. TVS will not share information with anyone except as detailed in our Privacy Policy (<http://www.trivalleystargazers.org/privacy.shtml>).

Mail this completed form along with a check to: Tri-Valley Stargazers, P.O. Box 2476, Livermore, CA 94551.